



Captain marvel: Aussie skipper Pat Cummins became the first player to breach the Rs 20 crore mark when Sunrisers Hyderabad edged out Royal Challengers Bangalore, Mumbai Indians, and Chennai Super Kings in a four-way bidding war to secure his services for Rs 20.5 crore. GETTY IMAGES

ones who backed them when they had hardly played T20 cricket," said Praveen Amre, the Delhi Capitals assistant coach. "Even this year, we wanted to have Kumar Kushagra with us. He is another guy we have backed, and hopefully, he will justify it because we have invested in and retained all the names I mentioned earlier. As team management, we are happy to back the youngsters as well."

Kushagra's fellow Jharkhand 'keeper-hitter Robin Minz fetched more than Rs. 3 crore towards the end of the auction. Tamil Nadu's left-arm spinner, M. Siddharth, went for Rs 2 crore plus, thus underscoring the extensive scouting system of IPL franchises.

The familiarity factor

Stephen Fleming has been the Chennai Super Kings head coach since the 2009 edition. The New

Zealand legend has brought the best out of Devon Conway at the top of the order. Conway will now have company in the Kiwi club at CSK, with the five-time champion adding Mitchell and Ravindra.

Daniel Vettori, another Kiwi legend, was Australia's assistant coach for the last two years. It wasn't just a coincidence, then, that immediately after Vettori was appointed head coach, Sunrisers Hyderabad went big on signing Pat Cummins and Travis Head.

A former India opener during the IPL retention show referred to it as the bias of overseas coaches. But more than the B-word, it's the familiarity and comfort with certain players that work for overseas coaches.

"You know their availability in their medical records, so that's a good starting point. There is a

comfort level there," Vettori said in Dubai.

"You have seen them up close and how they work and how they go about things. And so you have trust in their style of play and an understanding of how they can fit into a team. So I think that gives you a level of confidence that you can bring them into the environment."

The familiarity syndrome is not limited to overseas coaches. Kolkata Knight Riders signed wicketkeeper K.S. Bharat and promising Mumbai opener Angkrish Raghuvanshi, both mentored by its assistant coach Abhishek Nayar, at base price.

Price correction backfires

One of the features of mini-auctions is to rectify high prices, especially for some Indian signings. The Rajasthan Royals successfully did it with Jaydev Unadkat in 2019 and 2020. After